PEARSON Longman

The Economist

Intelligent Business

Style guide

Elementary
Business English

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The Economist

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Contents

Introduction	2
General rules	3
Organising your writing	4
Useful phrases	5
Messages and notes	6
Text messages	7
Emails	8
Letters	12
Faxes	16
Memos	18
Short reports	20
Notes on meetings	22
Check your writing:	
Common mistakes	24
Vocabulary (using a dictionary)	25
Reference:	
Numbers and dimensions	26
Dates, time and telephone numbers	27
Countries	28
Abbreviations	29
Punctuation	30

Introduction

When you write in another language, it can be difficult. It is also difficult to decide about the best way of communicating information. Email, letter, memo or report?

These things are important for good business relationships:

- Organise your ideas – make notes about what you want to say.
- Be clear – say things simply and clearly.
- Be polite – don't be rude or aggressive.
- Style – use the correct language for formal and informal situations.

It is also important to make your documents easy to read. This means using:

- correct grammar, vocabulary and spelling
- the right international conventions
- the best layout for your documents

The *Intelligent Business Style Guide* helps business students and people in work to learn the basic techniques of business writing. It contains samples of the most usual types of business document for elementary learners: emails, letters, memos, faxes, short internal reports and notes.

There is also a reference section, which explains some international conventions for business writing, to help you to check that your writing is correct. It also includes information on using numbers, abbreviations, punctuation and how to avoid common mistakes.

We hope you find the *Style Guide* useful and that it helps you to become more confident in your business writing.

General rules

Plan your writing

When you write anything longer than a short message:

1 **Make a plan:** Think about who you are writing to and what information you want to include.

2 **Write notes:** This is a practice version. Don't worry about details or correct language at this stage.

3 **Write a final version.**

4 **Check for mistakes and politeness.**

1 Make a plan

Think about these questions:

1 Who am I writing to? Who will read this?
2 Why am I writing? What do I want to say?
3 What does the reader know? What do they need to know?

Who am I writing to?
This question helps you to choose the right language. For friends and colleagues, you can use informal or semi-formal language. For superiors and customers, you should use formal language. But you should always be polite!

(see notes below on formal and informal language)

Why am I writing?
Do you want to: give information, make a request, give instructions, answer questions, or make a recommendation?

It is important to be clear about the purpose so that you can make it clear for your reader(s).

What does the reader know?
Does the reader already have some information about the subject or is it necessary to explain why you are writing? Too much information can be confusing. What are the most important points the reader needs to know?

2 Write notes

Decide about the information you need to include. Then write a practice version.

- Don't worry about mistakes – communicate the main ideas.
- Write short, clear sentences.
- Use a dictionary to find important words, but write as much as you can with the words you know.

3 Write a final version

At this stage, you can:

- Change the order of points.
- Add more information.
- Check that sentences are clear and correct.
- Use a grammar reference if you need to check the grammar.
- Use a dictionary if you need to check vocabulary.

4 Check for mistakes and politeness

Always check your writing before you send it. If you need to, you can re-write or ask an English speaker to check your writing.

- Have you included all the important information?
- Is the message clear and easy to read?
- Are there any grammar or spelling mistakes?
- Have you used a dictionary to check important vocabulary?
- Is the style right (formal or informal?)
- Is it polite?

Organising your writing

Formal and informal styles

Look at the table. It includes the main differences between formal and informal styles in English.

Note!
It is difficult to write good formal English. If you are writing an important letter or document, it is a good idea to ask another English speaker to check it for you.

Formal English	Informal / Semi-formal English
Always use complete sentences: *The budget for the project is $50,000.*	Sentences are not always complete: *Budget – $ 50,000*
Sometimes uses long or complex sentences.	Sentences are usually shorter and simpler.
Uses formal vocabulary, e.g. *receive, inform, request.*	Uses informal vocabulary, e.g. *get, tell, ask.*
Requests are longer: *Would it be possible to ...?*	We can make short requests: *Could you ...?*
Doesn't use contractions *I will send you the invoice.* *He is arriving at 7pm.* *They cannot come to the conference.*	Uses contractions: *I'll send you the invoice.* *He's arriving at 7pm.* *They can't come to the conference.*

Useful phrases

Socialising

Introductions	
Introducing yourself	*Hi / Hello, I'm [Mary Davies / a sales manager].*
Introducing others	*This is [Alan Drayton]. He/She's [with IBM / an IT manager].*
Responding	*Pleased to meet you. / Nice to meet you.*

Catching up	
Hello	Goodbye
How are you? / How are things? *How's business?*	*It was good to see / meet you again.*

Telephoning

	When you call	When you answer
Getting through	*My name is [Barbara Dean].* *Can I speak to [Bente Holm], please?*	*This is [Des Wyatt].* *[Des Wyatt] speaking.*
Explaining	*I'm calling about [my order].* *I'd like some information about [the conference dates].*	*I'm afraid he/she isn't in the office at the moment.*
Messages	*Can I leave a message, please?* *Can you take a message, please?*	*Can I take a message?* *I'll give him/her the message.*

Meetings

Asking for opinions	*What do you think of [the new logo]?* *Do you think that [we should change the design]?* *What's your opinion of [the logo]?*
Giving opinions	*I think that [the logo is too small].* *In my opinion, [it's too big].* *I like the [new logo] because [it's modern].*

Checking

Did you say [fifty or fifteen]? / Can you repeat that, please? / Sorry?

Messages and notes

It is often necessary to leave short messages for colleagues, for example if somebody phones when they are out. It is a good idea to keep your message short and simple and use informal language.

Messages often include the following information:
- contact details (e.g. name and phone number of caller)
- the time, day or date of the message

Sample messages

For: Fredrico Garcia
From: Mandy Crisp
Telephone number: 00 35 435 23535
Message: She can't have lunch today.
Message taken by: Sally
Date: 12 / 06 / 0_
Time: 10:30

Susanna
Jemma Frost called 11am today (Mon 4th).
Call her asap.
0 48 29 49 209

Sample notes

Martin,

Here's your copy of the finance report.

Hilary

Please turn off the lights when you leave the office.

Thank you!

Text messages

Text messages (also called SMS messages or 'texts') need to be very short. We can remove characters, and some words (especially articles). The only punctuation people generally use is ? and !.

Sometimes we replace words with numbers, symbols or single letters:

B	be
C	see
R	are
U	you
Y	why
2	too, to
4	for
&	and
@	at
#	number

We often take out vowels or consonants to make words shorter:

CHK	check
KNO	know
MSG	message
PLZ or *PLS*	please

Other abbreviations:

B4	before
CUL8R	see you later
GR8	great!
IDK	I don't know
L8	late
SRY	sorry
TMR	tomorrow
thanX	thanks
TTYL	talk to you later
UR	you are

We can show what we feel about something like this:

:-) ☺

:-(☹

Sample text messages

Please check my messages.



I'll be in work before 9 o'clock.



You're late – where are you?



Thanks for the great pictures!



Emails

We often use emails in business. It is a fast and cheap way to communicate. Sometimes the emails are very short and informal. Sometimes they are longer and more formal, like a letter.

The purpose of an email can be:

- To ask for or send information
- To ask people to do things
- To give instructions or directions
- To confirm arrangements that you have discussed by phone
- To send longer documents, e.g. reports

Key points to remember

Language and style:

- Keep your email short.
- Use short sentences and simple language.
- Do not write emails in CAPITAL letters – it looks like you are shouting.
- Use polite language for instructions and requests.
- Emails to senior people or people outside your company should be formal.
- Emails to colleagues and people in the same company can be semi-formal.
- Emails to team members, or to customers or suppliers that you know well, can be friendly and informal.
- Always read the email before you send it.
  Does it contain all the necessary information?
  Is the grammar, punctuation and level of politeness correct?

Structuring the message:

- Start with the most important information.
- Put less important information in the second paragraph.

Replying to messages:

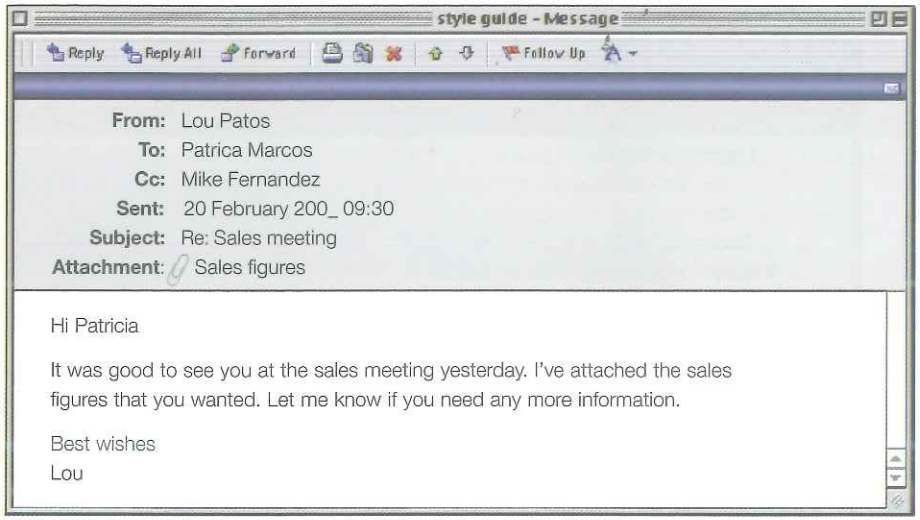
- Avoid replying with simply 'yes' or 'no'.
- Answer the question(s) that the original email asks.
- Be clear about what information you are referring to from the original email.

Layout

When you write a business email, you should follow the standard format. The email opposite shows where the following different components should appear on the page.

a name of the person / people sending the email
b name of the person / people the email is addressed to
c other person or people who will receive a copy of the email though it is not addressed directly to them
d the date and time when the email is sent
e information about the content of the email
f a document is attached
g opening
h body of the message
i closing
j name

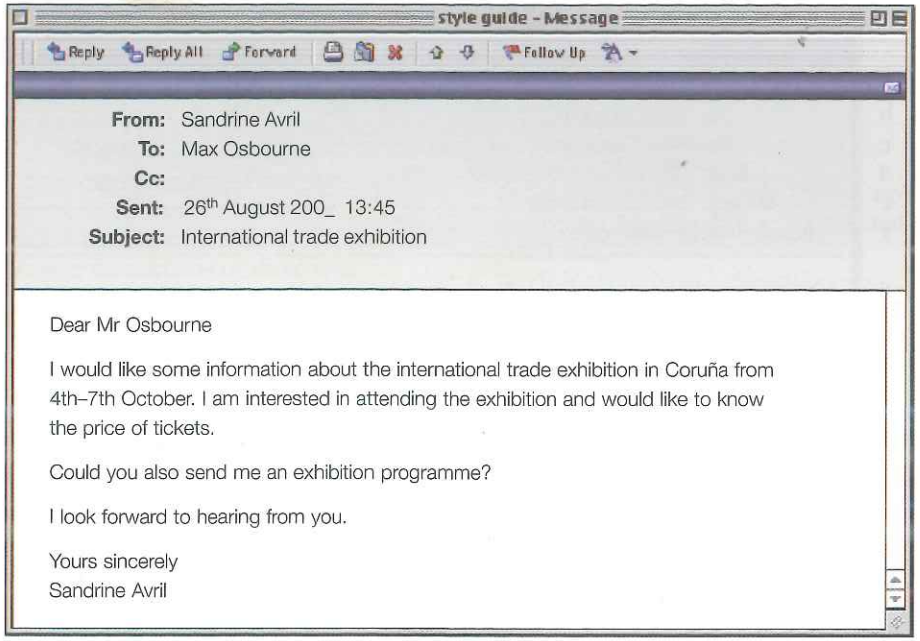
Sample email



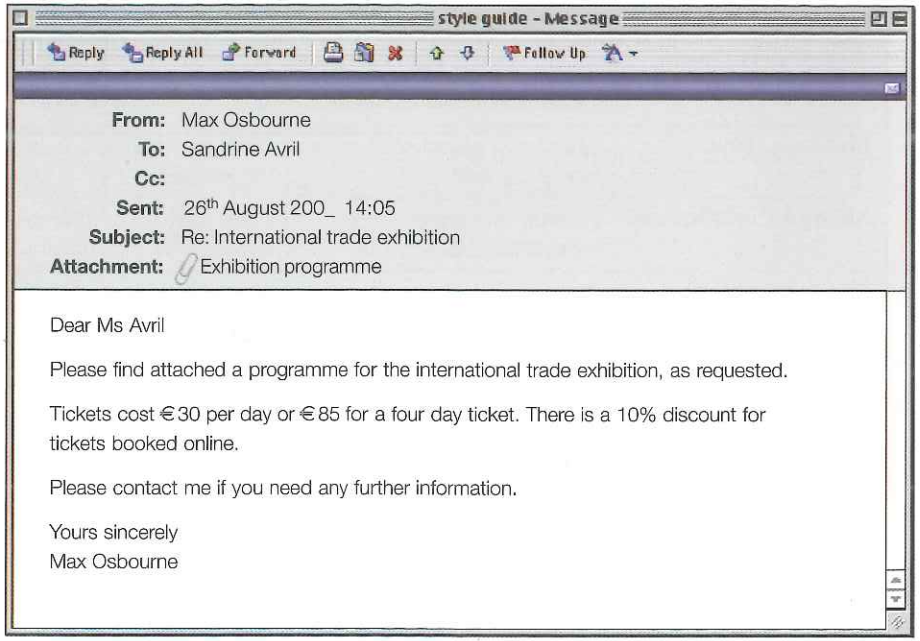
Useful phrases for emails	Formal	Semi-formal
Opening	*Dear Mr / Mrs / Ms / Miss Williams*	*Hello!* *Hi Frank*
Thanking	*Thank you for sending ...*	*Thanks for the ...*
Apologising	*We are sorry that the documents are late.* *Please accept our apologies.*	*Sorry the documents are late.*
Making a request	*Could you please send me a new price list?*	*Can you send me a new price list, please?*
Asking for information	*I would like some information about ...*	*Can I have some information about ...*
Giving information	*Please find attached the information you required.*	*Here's the information that you wanted.*
Final sentence	*I look forward to hearing from you.*	*Hope to hear from you soon.*
Closing phrases	*Yours sincerely*	*Best wishes* *Regards*

Sample emails

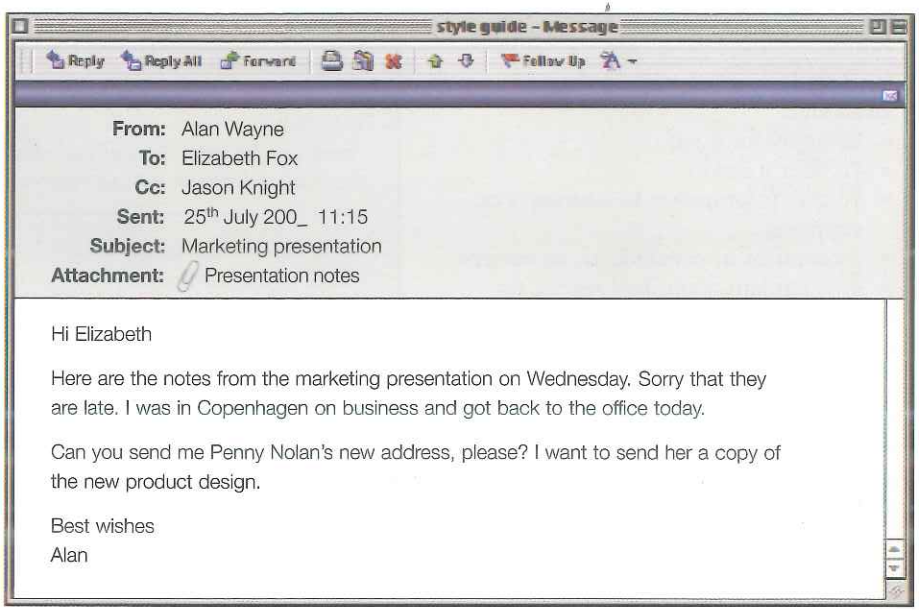
Formal



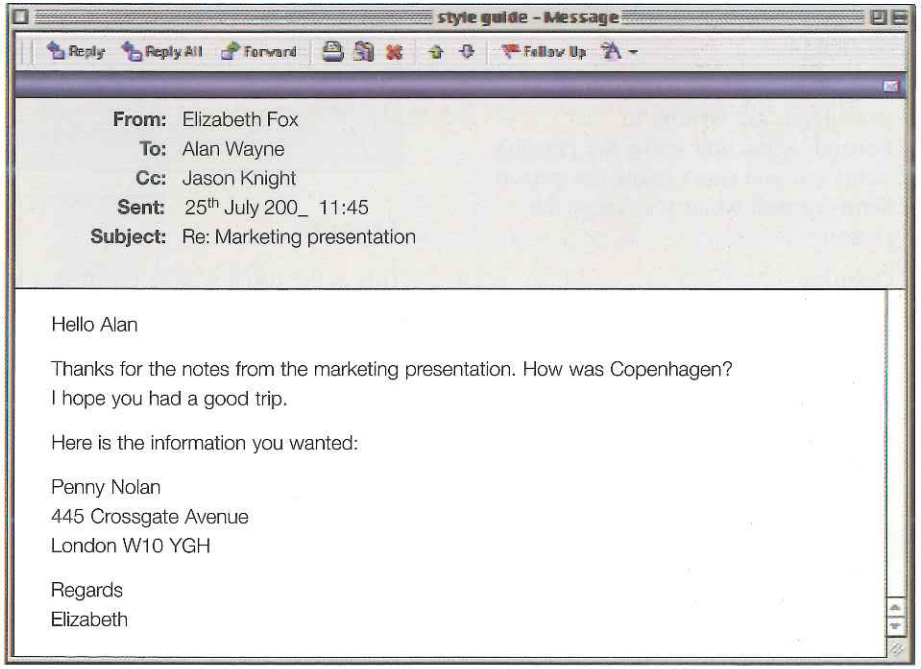
Reply



Semi-formal



Reply



Letters

For formal business communication, people usually write letters – not emails.

We usually write letters in these situations:

- To apply for a job
- To offer a service
- To give information to customers or suppliers
- To confirm or conclude an agreement
- To complain about bad service or products

It is important to write formal letters with correct language and in a more formal style than emails. You shouldn't write contractions (e.g. *I'll* or *we'd*). If you need to write a formal letter (for example to apply for a job), it is a good idea to get help from another English speaker.

Language styles

The style of the letter depends on how well you know the person you are writing to.

Very formal: when you don't know the person you are writing to
Formal: when you know the person's name but you don't know the person
Semi-formal: when you know the person

Opening
Very formal: *Dear Sir or Madam / Dear Sir*
Formal: *Dear Mr/Mrs/Ms Edwards*
Semi-formal: *Dear George*

Closing
Very formal: *Yours faithfully* (British English) / *Yours truly* (US English)
Formal: *Yours sincerely* (British English) / *Sincerely* (US English)
Semi-formal: *Best regards / Best wishes*

Useful phrases for letters

1 Referring to last contact
With reference to your letter of 12th May ...
Thank you for your letter of 20th March.
Following our telephone conversation today ...

2 Referring to the subject
(if not given in a subject line)
Regarding your request for a new price list ...
Re: New price list

3 Explaining why you are writing
I am writing to ask ... / to inform you ... / to confirm ...
I am interested in applying for ... / ordering ... / learning about ...

4 Referring to enclosures
(documents you send with the letter)
I am enclosing my CV.
Enclosed is a copy of my CV.

5 Requesting action
Could you please ...?

6 Polite endings
I look forward to hearing from you.
Thank you for your help in this matter.

Layout

This is the usual way to organise a letter. The letter opposite shows where you should include the following components.

a letterhead / address of writer
b name and address of recipient
c date
d opening
e subject line (**in bold**)
f body of the letter
g closing
h signature
i name of sender (and job title if appropriate)
j what is enclosed with the letter

Sample letter (confirming an agreement)

a
LK Training
79–81 Hills Road
Madingley
Bristol
BS10 8TV

b
Ella Barnes
PEMtec Electronics
Malvern Business Estate
Malvern
Worcestershire
W14 2JD

c
5th August 200_

d
Dear Ms Barnes,

e
Re: Computer training

f
Following our telephone conversation yesterday, I am writing to confirm the dates of the training courses that we discussed.

Training course 1	14–18 November
Training course 2	8–12 December

Julian McDonald, the course trainer, will contact you next week to talk about the software that your company uses. Enclosed is a map with the location and start and finish times of the courses.

g
Yours sincerely,

h
Adrian Kaplinsky

i
Adrian Kaplinsky
Project coordinator

j
Enc: map

Sample letters (offer a service and reply)

Milton Supplies
13 Farrow Way
Monmouth
NP25 8UQ
Tel: 00243 2424 2482430
LKing@Milton.com

Buying Manager
Fawbert and Young
Kenlow Industrial Estate
Birmingham
B12 D29

April 10th 200_

Dear Sir or Madam,
Subject: NG5X parts

I am writing regarding your recent article in Business Supply Monthly magazine. In the magazine you said that your company has a problem finding NG5X parts for your printing factory.

We are a company that manufactures NG5X parts and other printing equipment. We would be happy to send you samples or discuss your requirements. I am enclosing our brochure.

Please contact me if you need any further information.

Yours faithfully,

Lisa King

Lisa King
Sales manager
Enc: brochure

Reply

Dear Ms King,

Thank you for the Milton Supplies brochure, which arrived today.

We are interested in buying NG5X parts and also other items of equipment that you produce. I would like to arrange a meeting to talk about our requirements. Please contact my office to find a date that is good for you.

We look forward to doing business with Milton Supplies.

Yours sincerely,

Ramesh Azoor

Ramesh Azoor
Buying manager

Sample letter (applying for a job)

127 Magheru Blvd
Sector 1
Bucharest
Romania

Ricardo Valdez
GEFN Group
310 Canary Wharf
London
E14 0AQ
UK

4th October 200_

Dear Mt Valdez,

I am writing about your job advertisement in Graduate News on October 3rd. I would like to apply for the position of marketing manager. GEFN Group is a respected global organisation and I would be very interested in working for your company.

I worked as a marketing manager for three years at EDM, an international finance company. I have also studied in the USA and France, and I can speak four languages.

I am enclosing my curriculum vitae with this letter.

I look forward to hearing from you.

Yours sincerely,

Mirela Butacu

Mirela Butacu

Enc: CV

Faxes

Many people still use faxes in these situations:

- To place and confirm orders for goods and supplies
- To make hotel and travel bookings
- To request and confirm payment
- To make and answer enquiries
- To request action or give instructions
- To send copies of documents (e.g. fliers, order forms, invoices and contracts)

When people have important documents to send, they often send a copy by fax first, and the original document by post or courier later.

Useful phrases for faxes

Placing orders
We wish to place an order for ...
I look forward to receiving your confirmation.

Making hotel and travel bookings
I would like to book / make a reservation for ...

Confirming
Thank you for your order / your booking dated 3rd May.

Making enquiries and requests
Could you please fax your latest price list?
Could you send us by fax your price list and delivery dates?

Answering enquiries and giving information
Thank you for your enquiry.
Following your request for ...
We are pleased to inform you that ...
We are sending you our price list, as requested.

Layout

This is the usual way to organise notes on a meeting. The fax opposite shows where you should include the following components (b–f can be in a different order).

a letterhead (company name)
b name of person the fax is to
c name of person sending the fax
d sender's fax number
e date
f number of pages
g subject
h body of the message
i closing
j signature (hand written)

Sample fax

a

Howard Velmont Designs
56 Manningtree House
Sussex

Fax Transmission

b **TO:** Hawthorn Plastics, Auckland, New Zealand

c **FROM:** Vanessa Livingstone, Project manager

d **FAX NUMBER:** 00 57 9248 7738

e **DATE:** 11th January 200_

f **NUMBER OF PAGES (including this):** 2

---

g **Re: Changes to design**

h Please find attached the new design that you requested.

Could you let me know if the size is now correct? I will also send a copy of the design to you by mail. You should receive this by Friday.

I look forward to hearing from you.

i Regards

j *Howard Velmont*

Memos

A memo (full name: 'memorandum') is a short, official note. It is usually sent from one person to other people in the same company.

We send memos:

- To give information (e.g. about events, activities, changes)
- To ask for information (e.g. about holiday dates)
- To give instructions or remind people to take action (e.g. new procedures)
- To make recommendations (e.g. how to solve a problem)
- To send a report, summary, notes from a meeting, etc.

Layout

This is the usual way to organise a memo. The memo opposite shows where you should include the following components (a–d can be in a different order).

a name of person / people who will receive the memo
b name of person / people sending the memo
c the subject of the memo
d date
e Note that no opening is necessary
f main message
g action or recommendation
h name or initials of the person sending the memo, but this is not necessary
Note that no closing is necessary

Useful phrases for memos

Giving information
This is to inform you that ...
I am / We are pleased / sorry to inform you that ...
I / We wish to inform you ...

Requesting information
I / We would like to have ...
Could you give me / us ...?

Giving instructions
Please follow the new procedures.
Check ...
I / We want ...

Reminding people to do something
Don't forget to ...
Please remember to ...

Making recommendations
I / We think it is best to change suppler.
I / We recommend the new design.

Sending a report
Please see the attached report.

Asking for action
Please send your sales figures to Gillian by Tuesday.
Do ...
Write ...
Phone ...
Contact ...

Sample memo

MEMO

a **To:** Marketing department
b **From:** Felix Moyles, Sales director
c **Subject:** Dates for sales conference
d **Date:** 2nd September

e

f This is to inform you that the sales conference will have a new date and location this year.

Sales conference

New date	**New location**
18–20 November	Epoc Conference Centre

g We recommend staff to contact the travel office as soon as possible to book accommodation for the conference.

h FM

Short reports

Types of report

Visit report – gives details of a trip or visit
Progress report – tells other people about the progress of a project
Departmental report – what you have done recently in your department
Research report – reports on research, gives conclusions and recommendations
Proposal – makes suggestions for action, with facts and arguments

Reports can be:
1 **External** – for people from another company (e.g. clients or suppliers). These reports are formal. Write full sentences and avoid contractions (*I'll*, *You're*, etc.).
2 **Internal** – for people in your own company. Reports for senior managers should be formal. Reports for colleagues can be semi-formal.

Layout

This is the usual way to organise a report. The report opposite shows where you should include the following components.

a title of report
b introduction – purpose of report
c main part of report organised into sections with headings
d bullet points to make points clear and easy to read
e conclusion with recommendations for future action

Useful phrases for reports

Giving the objectives
The purpose of this report is to ...
This report shows ... / describes ... / gives the results of ...

Describing activities you have carried out
I have started a new project to ...
We have completed work on ...

Giving facts
Profits remained steady last year.
The cost of materials increased by twelve per cent.

Giving reasons
We increased our prices because ...
The project was behind schedule because of ...

Referring to illustrations
See Figure 14.
Figure 14 shows ...

Giving opinions or comments
The sales last month were excellent.
The new design is successful.

Giving the conclusion
We need to reduce costs by five per cent.
The results of the survey show that ...

Making a recommendation
We recommend that ...
We should ...

Sample short report

a

Martinez House project report

b

Introduction
The purpose of this report is to look at the reasons why the Martinez House project was over budget and behind schedule. Martinez House is a new building project with seventy apartments for use by businesspeople when they visit conferences in the area.

c

c Budget
The budget for the project was €2.5 million. The budget was agreed in January before building started. There were a number of reasons that made the project go over budget.

d

- Cost of building materials – these went up by fifteen per cent during the project
- Cost of skilled workers – wages increased by eight per cent
- Changes to the original designs for the apartments

Schedule
In the contract, we agreed to finish the project by October. The architects finished the original design on schedule and this was sent to the building committee. The committee suggested a number of changes to the plan. The architects agreed to make the changes but this took four weeks. The new design was better but because of the delay building started one month late.

e

Conclusion
Martinez House is successful and popular with businesspeople. The project has made a profit and bookings will continue to increase during the next twelve months. For future projects, we need to speak to our suppliers and agree a price for materials before the project begins. We should also employ a training manager to teach our workers new skills. Finally, the committee should agree a new deadline if they make changes to future building plans.

Notes on meetings

Minutes are a formal record of a meeting. One person is usually in charge of writing and typing the minutes and sending them to everyone that attended the meeting (and also to people who were not able to be at the meeting). Many informal meetings don't need minutes. However, it is a good idea if someone at the meeting takes *notes*.

Why keep a record of a meeting?

- To remind people about important points
- To inform people who were not at the meeting about what happened
- To make sure everyone knows what decisions were taken
- To record the names of people who will be responsible for certain actions
- To remind people about action points and deadlines
- To check that everyone agrees what took place at the meeting

What should you include in your notes?

- Subject and date of the meeting (e.g. Project team meeting, 14th July 200_)
- A list of the people who attended (sometimes just their initials)
- A list of the points that you discussed
- Important new information (e.g. updates, problems)
- A record of decisions
- Actions to be taken and who is responsible for each action
- The deadline for completing each action
- The date of the next meeting

If your notes are for colleagues, you can write in an informal style (with contractions and abbreviations that everyone can understand). Full sentences are not always necessary.

Useful phrases for minutes

Giving the subject
Meeting to discuss ...

Saying who attended
Present: ...

Reporting discussion
We discussed ...
We brainstormed ...
We agreed ...

Reporting decisions
We decided that ...

Reporting action points
Action: Charlotte to check sales figures / Charlotte will check sales figures
Deadline: 21st November

Giving details of the next meeting
Next meeting: 10.00, 22nd November, Room 4

Layout

This is the usual way to organise notes on a meeting. The notes opposite show where you should include the following components.

a subject and date
b people who attended
c agenda points (numbered 1, 2, etc.) and decisions
d action points and people responsible
e date or time for completing actions
f details of next meeting

Sample notes on a meeting

a **Meeting to discuss Staff social event,**
12th March 200_

b Present: BD, PJ, GW, KT

c **1 Suggestions for events**
We brainstormed the following ideas:
- picnic
- adventure day
- boat trip

We decided to ask staff which event they prefer.

2 Date for the event
We agreed that the event should be on Saturday June 25th.

3 Budget
Management has given us a budget of €1,300 for the event. We could also ask staff to buy tickets for guests to increase the money that we have for food and drink.

d **Actions:**
BD to research costs
PJ to design an information document for staff
GW to arrange a staff meeting to choose an event

e Deadline: 20th March

f **Next meeting: 11.30am 21st March, KT's office**

Check your writing!

Common mistakes

We often make the same mistakes again and again. It is useful to identify typical mistakes as this helps us not to repeat them. When you check your writing, first look for mistakes that you know you make regularly. Then check it again for some of the other common mistakes below:

Common mistakes	Corrected version
Singular and plural He *want* a meeting every week. The information you want *are* in the email. *Does* you have an appointment? They *doesn't* like the new design.	He *wants* a meeting every week. The information you want *is* in the email. *Do* you have an appointment? They *don't* like the new design.
Quantity and number How *many* money is in the account? I'd like *an* information about the hotel.	How *much* money is in the account? I'd like *some* information about the hotel.
Verb tenses We *are* always *having* meetings on Monday. At the moment, I *work* on a project Last year we *make* a profit. I *live* in Italy since 2006.	We always *have* meetings on Monday. At the moment *I'm working* on a project. Last year we *made* a profit. *I have lived* in Italy since 2006.
Modal verbs We *should* to increase our prices. He *could buys* a new car.	We *should* increase our prices. He *could buy* a new car.
Articles He is lawyer. I am *a* engineer. She is *a* Polish. Open *a* door, please.	He is *a* lawyer. I am *an* engineer. She is Polish. Open *the* door, please.
Questions What time *it is*? How much *the ticket costs*? *You can* tell me the directions?	What time *is it*? How much *does the ticket cost*? *Can you* tell me the directions?
Word order I am visiting *tomorrow the Prague office*. Can I *a message leave*? They *deliver never* on time.	I am visiting *the Prague office tomorrow*. Can I *leave a message*? They *never deliver* on time.
Prepositions The factory in Tokyo opened *at* January. We finished the report *on* last Tuesday. They have been our supplier *for* 2007. I have been your customer *since* two years.	The factory in Tokyo opened *in* January. We finished the report last Tuesday. They have been our supplier *since* 2007. I have been your customer *for* two years.

Vocabulary

It is a good idea to start a vocabulary notebook to put new words in.

It is useful to do the following:

- Write the word in a sentence to help you to remember how it is used
- If it is part of a word family, show other parts of the word family that are useful for you (e.g. verb – *produce*, noun – *product*).
- Write what the word is (verb, noun, adjective, adverb, etc.).
- Write phonetic symbols for words that are difficult to pronounce.
- Show word stress.

You can organise a vocabulary notebook into two parts.
The first part can be for new words.
Then you can organise the new words and phrases into groups (for example, telephoning, food, etc).
It is important to review new words and phrases regularly to help you increase your vocabulary.

False friends

Be careful about the use of some words – they don't always have the same meaning in English as in your own language. The table below shows some examples of words that can be confusing:

Use a dictionary

An English-English dictionary gives much more detailed and precise information than a bi-lingual dictionary. A good dictionary will give you help with:

- correct spelling
- pronunciation
- definitions for each different use of a word
- word families: noun, verb, adjective forms
- information about nouns: if countable or uncountable, plural forms
- irregular forms of verbs
- information about verbs: do they take a direct object, indirect object or no object?
- prepositions commonly used with certain verbs or adjectives
- example sentences
- British and American English differences

A dictionary such as the *Longman Business English* dictionary will give you definitions of business terms and general words that have a special meaning in business. You will also find the *Longman Wordwise* dictionary helpful for general words.

Word	Doesn't mean ...	Means ...	Example
actually	now	really, in fact	*Carl thought he was late for the meeting, but* ***actually*** *he was on time.*
eventually	possibly	in the end, after some time	*The journey took a long time, but we* ***eventually*** *arrived at the hotel.*
technique	technology	a method or way of doing something	*What* ***techniques*** *do you use for learning vocabulary?*

Numbers and dimensions

Numbers

We often need to write numbers in messages, emails and reports. Here is a guide to writing numbers:

1 one	12 twelve	22 twenty-two
2 two	13 thirteen	23 twenty-three
3 three	14 fourteen	30 thirty
4 four	15 fifteen	40 forty
5 five	16 sixteen	50 fifty
6 six	17 seventeen	60 sixty
7 seven	18 eighteen	70 seventy
8 eight	19 nineteen	80 eighty
9 nine	20 twenty	90 ninety
10 ten	21 twenty-one	
11 eleven		

100 a hundred / one hundred
101 a / one hundred and one
102 a / one hundred and two [British English]
[In US English, people don't say or write *and*: one hundred one; six hundred fourteen]

1,000 a / one thousand
[Note that both British and American English use a *comma* when writing numbers in thousands]

1,001 a / one thousand and one
1,100 a / one thousand one hundred
5,000 five thousand
1,000,000 / 1m a / one million
1,000,000,000 / 1bn a / one billion
[Note that *a billion* can also mean: 1,000,000,000,000]

Decimals
1.5 one point five
1.21 one point two one
[Note that both British and American English use a *point* when writing decimals]

Fractions
½ (a) half / one half
¼ (a) quarter / one quarter
⅓ (a) third

Plural numbers

We only use numbers in the plural form to mean *a lot*, and they are then followed by *of*:

✗ Five hundreds people went to the conference.
✓ Hundreds of people went to the conference.

✗ The new building cost fifteen millions.
✓ The new building cost millions of dollars.

Zero
You can say 0 as *zero* or *nought*.

Ordinal numbers

We use ordinal numbers when we say dates.

1st	first	17th	seventeenth
2nd	second	18th	eighteenth
3rd	third	19th	nineteenth
4th	fourth	20th	twentieth
5th	fifth	21st	twenty-first
6th	sixth	22nd	twenty second
7th	seventh	23rd	twenty-third
8th	eighth	24th	twenty-fourth
9th	ninth	25th	twenty-fifth
10th	tenth	26th	twenty-sixth
11th	eleventh	27th	twenty-seventh
12th	twelfth	28th	twenty-eighth
13th	thirteenth	29th	twenty-ninth
14th	fourteenth	30th	thirtieth
15th	fifteenth	31st	thirty-first
16th	sixteenth		

Dimensions

In order of size from small to big:
millimetres centimetres metres

2m x 35cm: *It's two metres by thirty-five centimetres.*
It's 70 millimetres long. / The length is 70 millimetres.
It's 56 centimetres wide. / The width is 56 centimetres.
It's two metres high. / The height is two metres.

Dates, times and telephone numbers

Dates

The UK and most European countries put the day before the month: *21st July*

In the US and some other countries, the month comes first: *July 21*

We can say dates in two ways:
10th December — *The tenth of December*
or — *December the tenth*

Years

We write: *1807* *1995* *2008*
We say: *eighteen oh seven*
nineteen ninety-five
two thousand and eight

Times

English speakers don't often use the 24-hour clock, but prefer am and pm.

Morning = am
Afternoon / evening = pm

The conference starts at 10am.
The meeting finishes at 5pm.

We use *am* and *pm* when we say the hour before the minutes:
five ten am, five fifteen am, five forty pm, five fifty-six pm, etc.

but not when we say the minutes first:
ten past five, quarter past five, twenty to six, etc.

We can say *five pm* but not *five ~~o'clock~~ pm*

The 24-hour clock is used for travel times, train timetables, flight times, etc.

My plane leaves at 14:45 and arrives at 18:20.

Note that we don't usually write: *o'clock* or *half past, quarter to*, etc. We usually use these expressions when we are speaking.

Preposition of time

on	in	at
Friday	2009	7:30 (seven thirty)
the sixteenth of May	two hours	night
Monday morning	the evening	the weekend
	July	New Year
	the spring	

Telephone numbers

We usually say telephone numbers as smaller groups of numbers.

We write: 36288 419005
We say: three six two, double eight, four one nine, double oh five

Telephone numbers can also have a country code or an area code.

There are some differences in the the way we usually say telephone numbers in the UK and the USA.

040
UK oh-four-oh
USA zero four zero

3557
UK three double fove seven
USA three five five seven

Countries

Country	Capital	Nationality	Currency
Argentina	Buenos Aires	Argentinian	Argentine peso
Australia	Canberra	Australian	Australian dollar
Austria	Vienna	Austrian	euro
Belgium	Brussels	Belgian	euro
Brazil	Brasilia	Brazilian	real
China	Beijing	Chinese	yuan
Croatia	Zagreb	Croatian	kuna
Czech Republic	Prague	Czech	koruna
Denmark	Copenhagen	Danish	Danish krone
Finland	Helsinki	Finnish	euro
France	Paris	French	euro
Germany	Berlin	German	euro
Greece	Athens	Greek	euro
Hungary	Budapest	Hungarian	forint
India	New Delhi	Indian	rupee
Ireland	Dublin	Irish	euro
Italy	Rome	Italian	euro
Japan	Tokyo	Japanese	yen
Kuwait	Kuwait City	Kuwaiti	dinar
Luxembourg	Luxembourg	of Luxembourg	euro
Malaysia	Kuala Lumpur	Malaysian	ringgit
Netherlands	Amsterdam	Dutch	euro
New Zealand	Wellington	New Zealander	New Zealand dollar
Norway	Oslo	Norwegian	Norwegian krone
Poland	Warsaw	Polish	zloty
Portugal	Lisbon	Portuguese	euro
Romania	Bucharest	Romanian	leu
Russia	Moscow	Russian	rouble
Saudi Arabia	Riyadh	Saudi	riyal
Slovakia	Bratislava	Slovakian	Slovakian koruna
Slovenia	Ljubljana	Slovenian	euro
Spain	Madrid	Spanish	euro
Sweden	Stockholm	Swedish	Swedish krona
Switzerland	Berne	Swiss	Swiss franc
Turkey	Ankara	Turkish	Turkish lira
United Kingdom (the UK)	London	British	pound sterling
United States of America (the USA)	Washington DC	American	US dollar

Abbreviations

There are many common abbreviations in written English. Notice that these may be different from the abbreviations you use in your language for the same things.

Job titles

CEO	Chief Executive Officer
CFO	Chief Financial Officer
CIO	Chief Information Officer
CCO	Chief Communications Officer
MD	Managing Director

Names of organisations

ASEAN	Association of South East Asian Nations
EU	European Union
IMF	International Monetary Fund
NAFTA	North American Free Trade Agreement
UN	United Nations
WTO	World Trade Organisation

Countries

KSA	Kingdom of Saudi Arabia
RSA	Republic of South Africa
UAE	United Arab Emirates
UK	United Kingdom
US/USA	United States (of America)

Common business terms

a/c	account
admin.	administration
AGM	Annual General Meeting
AOB	Any other business
B2B	Business to business
B2C	Business to consumer
Co.	company
Dept.	department
GDP	Gross domestic product
HR	Human resources
Inc.	incorporated
Ltd.	limited
p.a.	per annum
P&L	profit and loss
PLC	public limited company
R&D	research and development
ROI	return on investment
USP	unique selling point
VAT	value added tax

Common internet and computer terms

FAQ	frequently asked questions
HTML	hypertext markup language
PDF	portable document format
RAM	random access memory
ROM	read only memory
www	world wide web

Abbreviations often used in documents, emails and letters

Approx.	approximately
ASAP	as soon as possible
Attn.	attention
Cc	copy / copies circulated (to ...)
Doc	document
ETA	estimated time of arrival
FAO	for the attention of ...
Fig.	figure
p	page
pp	pages
PTO	please turn over
Ref.	reference

Other

e.g.	for example
etc.	and so on
ID	identity
i.e.	that is (that means)
NB!	Please note!
no.	number
#	number

Punctuation

Punctuation is important: it helps you to make the meaning of sentences clear.

Notice that the rules for punctuation in English may be a little different from the rules in your own language – especially for commas.

• full stop .

full stop (US English: period)

- use to mark the end of a sentence
- use in some abbreviations (e.g., i.e.)

• comma ,

commas help to divide sentences into meaningful parts

- use after an initial phrase or clause

After some discussion, we agreed to sign the contract.
If you need help, ask at the reception desk.

- use when you want to write a phrase or clause in the middle of a sentence to explain something

John Dee, the Managing Director, attended the sales conference.

J.D. Supplies, the company that supplies our components, is late with their delivery.

- use in lists

The company produces engines, machinery, electric appliances and computers.

• question mark ?

- use at the end of a question

How much does this cost?

• exclamation mark !

- use in informal writing to show the importance of something, or to show surprise

Don't forget Sonya's birthday!
I passed my test!

• colon :

- use to introduce a list

Here are the dates for the next three meetings: *April 21st*
July 3rd
October 29th

• dash –

- use in informal writing to introduce comments and explanations

I agree with your suggestion – it's an excellent idea!

I disagree with the proposal – I think it's too expensive.

• brackets ( ) OR [ ]

- use to present extra information which is not an essential part of the main message.

Our main markets are in Europe (25 per cent of sales), North America (35 per cent) and Asia Pacific (40 per cent).

• apostrophe 's OR s'

- use to show that something belongs to a person or group of people

The apostrophe comes in front of the 's' when the noun is singular

The report is on the manager's desk.
(There is one manager)

It comes after the final 's' when the noun is plural

This is the employees' problem.
(There are several employees)

Notice that we also use an apostrophe in abbreviated forms to show where there are letters missing.

I'll *he's* *they'd* *we're*

• inverted commas / speech marks / quotation marks '...' OR "..."

- use to show the exact words that somebody has written or spoken. Use a comma or commas to separate the quotation from the rest of the sentence

"It's important to do this ourselves," says the company training manager.

• hyphen -

- use this between the two parts of a compound noun or adjective

Dino and Miles are co-directors of the company.
It is a low-cost product.
He's on a two-day training course.
I work in an open-plan office

When do I use capital letters?

- ✓ To begin a sentence
- ✓ Titles and headings of books, articles, etc. (*Intelligent Business*)
- ✓ With people's names, names of companies, organisations and official bodies (*John Smith, IBM, The World Health Organisation*)
- ✓ Authorities (*the Government, the Queen*)
- ✓ Countries, nationalities, adjectives relating to nationalities, languages (*In France, French people speak French*)
- ✓ Days of the week, months of the year
- ✓ Personal pronoun: *I*
- ✓ With certain abbreviations (*GDP, VAT, NB*) [see list of abbreviations]

Don't use capital letters ...

- ✗ With other personal pronouns
- ✗ With nouns that are not names

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